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UNDERSTANDING HOW WORK–LIFE BALANCE SHAPES EMPLOYEE PRODUCTIVITY IN INDIAN WORKPLACES: INSIGHTS INTO WELL-BEING, STRESS, AND SUPPORTIVE HR PRACTICES

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ABSTRACT:

Contemporary Indian organisations are navigating mounting pressure to address work-life balance (WLB) as a central human resource imperative. The post-pandemic restructuring of work characterized by blurred professional boundaries and heightened psychological demands has intensified the urgency of this challenge. This study empirically investigates the interplay among WLB, occupational stress, perceived organisational support, and job performance across multiple industry sectors in India. Primary data collected from a structured survey instrument administered to 92 validated respondents drawn from a sampling pool of 100–150 professionals. The participant base was predominantly youthful, with 66.3% below 25 years of age and 30.4% between 25 and 34 years, spanning industries including education, information technology, banking and finance, and healthcare. Survey results shows occupational stress is moderate to elevated (composite mean = 3.11 on a five-point Likert scale), while WLB satisfaction registers below the midpoint (mean = 2.88), pointing to widespread dissatisfaction. Perceived support from HR policies and flexible work provisions was rated moderately (mean = 3.18). Notwithstanding these adverse conditions, respondents reported above-average motivation and productivity (mean = 3.41), a finding that signals the role of intrinsic drive and professional commitment as resilience factors. A notable discovery is that hybrid work adopters reported the lowest WLB scores (2.41) lower than both fully office-based (3.00) and fully remote (2.93) employees challenging prevailing assumptions about the benefits of flexible arrangements. Actionable recommendations for HR professionals and organisational policymakers are presented, encompassing equitable workload distribution, flexible scheduling frameworks, and strengthened employee wellness infrastructure.

Keywords: Work-Life Balance, Occupational Stress, Organisational Support, Employee Well-Being, Job Performance, Flexible Work Arrangements, Human Resource Management, India

1. Introduction

The challenge of reconciling professional obligations with personal well-being has come from a niche academic concern into one of the most consequential issues confronting modern organisations. Work-life balance is basically your ability to handle your job and your own life without feeling like you're failing at both or running on empty. In India, this has become a massive struggle. Between the fast-moving economy, the rise of freelance gig work, and the old-school culture where staying late is seen as a badge of loyalty, the line between "at work" and "at home" has pretty much vanished.

When the pandemic hit, everyone thought remote work would be the solution. But it actually backfired for most of the people. Instead of saving time, many found they work for longer hours because their living room became their office. The "always-on" culture just got worse, leading to more stress and burnout.

For younger professionals in India, this is a huge deal. They aren't just looking for a paycheck; they want flexibility and a life outside of their cubicle.

The problem is that most studies on this topic only focus on big industries like IT or banking. They treat work-life balance like it's a simple, standalone issue. This research takes a different approach. It looks at several different industries and explores how stress, company support, and personal well-being all tie together to affect how someone actually performs at their job. The theoretical scaffolding of this study rests on three complementary frameworks. The Work-Family Conflict Theory (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985) illuminates the mechanisms through which competing role demands generate tension. The Demand-Control-Support Model (Karasek, 1979; Johnson & Hall, 1988) explicates how job demands, decisional latitude, and social support interact to shape stress outcomes. The Conservation of course Theory (Hobfoll, 1989) provides a resource-based lens through which the draining of one's own assets under chronic work demands can be understood as a precursor to diminished well-being and impaired performance.

This study pursues four interconnected objectives: (1) to document prevailing levels of work-life balance, occupational stress, and organisational support among a cross-sectional sample of Indian professionals; (2) to examine how different work arrangements, office-based, remote, and hybrid relate to WLB perceptions; (3) to assess the influence of occupational stress on employee productivity and performance; and (4) to identify the extent to which organisational HR policies and managerial support moderate work-life conflict. The paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 reviews extant literature; Section 3 details the research methodology; Section 4 presents empirical findings; Section 5 interprets and discusses key outcomes; and Section 6 draws conclusions with recommendations for practice and future inquiry.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Conceptualizing Work-Life Balance

Work-life balance is a multifaceted construct whose conceptual contours have shifted considerably across four decades of organisational scholarship. Earlier theoretical treatments tended to frame WLB primarily in terms of the negative spillover from demanding work roles into family life that is, as the mitigation of work-family conflict (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985). More later-day scholarship has widened this conceptualization to embrace positive enrichment and mutual reinforcement across life domains, recognizing that professional and personal roles need not be adversarial but can, under the right conditions, be mutually enabling (Greenhaus & Powell, 2006; Carlson et al., 2006). Haar et al. (2014) demonstrated through a multi-country study that WLB is a robust predictor of both professional and personal satisfaction, with effects that transcend specific cultural contexts. Researchers situating WLB within the Indian milieu have drawn attention to the cultural specificity of these experiences. Ransome (2007) and Singh (2010) observed that collectivist family obligations, asymmetric gender role expectations, and informally sanctioned extended working norms generate a distinctive constellation of pressures for Indian professionals. The accelerating expansion of India's service economy spanning IT, banking, and education has been accompanied by rising incidence of burnout and role conflict, suggesting a systemic lag between evolving employee wish and prevailing organisational cultures.

2.2 Occupational Stress and Its Consequences

Occupational stress manifests as the physiological and psychological response set off when particular perceive that environmental demands outpace their coping capacity (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). The demand-control-support model, initially advanced by Karasek (1979) and subsequently extended by Johnson and Hall (1988), holds that the combination of elevated job demands, constrained decision latitude, and insufficient collegial support constitutes the principal antecedent of work-induced stress and its sequelae, including burnout, absenteeism, and performance deterioration.

Empirical scholarship has consistently corroborated these theoretical predictions. LePine et al. (2005) distinguished between challenge and hindrance stressors in a meta-analysis, revealing that their effects on motivation and output diverge appreciably. Through the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) framework, Bakker and Demerouti (2007) elaborated the pathways through which unabated job demands erode personal energy, ultimately precipitating disengagement and reduced effectiveness. Within the Indian context, Pestonjee and Pandey (2013) established that occupational stress bears a noteworthy positive syndicate with job dissatisfaction and turnover intention among finance sector professionals.

2.3 Organizational Support and HR Policy Effectiveness

Organisational support theory, as articulated by Eisenberger et al. (1986), posits that employees construct generalised beliefs about the degree to which their employer worth their benefaction and attends to their welfare. High perceived organisational support (POS) is reliably associated with heightened organisational commitment, lower absenteeism, and stronger in-role performance. Successive scholarship has habitual that POS umpire the bond between HR interventions spanning flexible work arrangements, leave entitlements, and wellness programmers and employee outcomes (Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002).

The role of immediate managerial support as a proximal determinant of WLB has garnered increasing research attention. Thomas and Ganster (1995) demonstrated that supervisor endorsement of family-friendly practices substantially reduces work-family conflict, irrespective of formal organisational policy. Kossek et al. (2011) subsequently found that employees who judge their line managers as genuinely supportive of WLB are less prone to presenteeism and report superior psychological well-being. In hierarchically structured Indian organisations, where managerial authority substantially shapes workplace norms, the calibre of supervisor-subordinate relationships may carry particularly pronounced implications for WLB outcomes.

2.4 Work Arrangements and the Hybrid Work Paradox

The proliferation of non-standard work arrangements including telecommuting, flextime, compressed working weeks, and hybrid models represents one of the most consequential organisational developments of the past decade. Proponents argue that these arrangements expand employee autonomy, reduce commuting burdens, and facilitate better articulation of work and personal responsibilities (Hill et al., 2008). The empirical record is, however, equivocal. Whilst some studies affirm that flexible arrangements improve WLB and attenuate stress (Allen et al., 2013), others have identified a flexibility paradox in which remote access fosters boundary-spanning behaviours, persistent connectivity, and intensified work demands that ultimately subvert well-being (Kelliher & Anderson, 2010).

Hybrid arrangements present a particularly complex challenge. Employees navigating transitions between home and office contexts are required to manage two distinct sets of expectations and social conventions, which can amplify role ambiguity and curtail the psychological detachment from work that is essential to recovery (Sonnentag & Fritz, 2015). These theoretical considerations furnish critical interpretive context for the empirical findings reported in Section 4.

2.5 Research Gaps and Study Contribution

Despite the voluminous scholarly output on work-life balance, several significant gaps persist. First, studies that simultaneously examine the interplay among WLB, occupational stress, organisational support, and job performance within a single integrated framework drawing on primary data from India's multi-sector workforce remain scarce. Second, the comparative analysis of diverse work arrangements in the post-pandemic era, when hybrid models have become mainstream, is theoretically underdeveloped. Third, extant Indian studies are predominantly single-sector in design, limiting their generalisability. This investigation addresses all three gaps by deploying a multi-sectoral sample, a multidimensional measurement instrument, and an integrative analytical strategy.

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design

It focus on a quantitative, descriptive-cum-analytical design. A cross-sectional survey methodology was used to gather primary data from employed professionals across multiple sectors in India. The cross-sectional design was considered fitting for capturing a contemporaneous snapshot of WLB experiences and related constructs. The probe is grounded in a positivist epistemological orientation, utilising structured measurement tools to generate objective, statistically analyzable data.

3.2 Sampling Strategy and Data Collection

A comfort sampling way was used, targeting working professionals accessible through masterful networks, educational institutions, and digital platforms. Between February and March 2026, questionnaires were given out to a sample pool of 100–150 individuals across multiple channels. Following a systematic data validation process, which screened for incomplete responses, inconsistent answering patterns, and duplicate submissions a final usable sample of 92 responses was retained. The validation retention rate ranged from approximately 61% to 92%, depending on the upper bound of the initial distribution. The survey was administered digitally via Google Forms to focus on coverage while minimizing interviewer-related bias. Participants were guaranteed anonymity and voluntary participation in accordance with applicable ethical research standards.

3.3 Measurement Instrument

The questionnaire comprised 25 items organised across six thematic modules: (1) demographic and employment characteristics (7 items); (2) workload and WLB perception (4 items, Q8–Q11); (3) organisational flexibility and policy support (2 items, Q12–Q13); (4) occupational stress and well-being (5 items, Q14–Q18); (5) productivity and job performance (4 items, Q19–Q22); and (6) managerial and HR support (2 items, Q23–

Q24), supplemented by one open-ended item inviting suggestions for organizational improvement (Q25). Items in modules 2–6 were measured on a five-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree/Never to 5 = Strongly Agree/Always). Demographic items utilized nominal and ordinal categorical response formats. Instrument items were developed in alignment with validated constructs from the WLB, stress, and organisational support literature, adapted to reflect the realities of the Indian professional environment.

3.4 Data Analyze

Data used descriptive statistical procedures, incorporating frequency distributions, percentage calculations, and measures of central tendency (mean) and dispersion (standard deviation). For thematic synthesis, composite scores were constructed in each domain; WLB Score (Q10 + Q11), Occupational Stress Score (Q14 + Q15 + Q16), Organisational Support Score (Q17 + Q23 + Q24), and Job Performance Score (Q19 + Q20 + Q21 + Q22). Cross-tabulation analysis was applied to investigate associations between work arrangement type and WLB scores, and between daily working hours and stress levels. Open-ended responses to Q25 were subjected to content analysis to identify recurrent thematic priorities.

4. Data Analysis

4.1 Demographic Profile of Respondents

Table 1 presents the demographic and employment profile of the 92 participants. The sample is characterised by a predominantly youthful workforce: 66.3% of respondents were below 25 years of age and 30.4% fell within the 25–34 bracket, reflecting the early-career orientation of the survey population. Gender distribution skewed female (66.3%), with male respondents constituting 31.5% and 2.2% preferring non-disclosure. Sector representation was led by education (43.5%), followed by IT/Software (14.1%) and banking/finance (7.6%). Work experience was concentrated at the early-career end, with 63.0% reporting under one year in employment. In terms of primary work arrangement, 46.7% were office-based, 30.4% worked from home, and 17.4% operated on a hybrid basis. Fifty per cent of respondents worked under eight hours daily; however, 82.7% reported working beyond official hours at least occasionally, and 39.2% did so often or always underscoring a pervasive culture of overtime.

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents (N = 92)

Variable	Category	Frequency (n)	Percentage (%)
Age Group	Below 25	61	66.3%
	25–34	28	30.4%

	35–44	1	1.1%
	45–54	2	2.2%
Gender	Female	61	66.3%
	Male	29	31.5%
	Prefer not to say	2	2.2%
Sector	Education	40	43.5%
	IT / Software	13	14.1%
	Banking / Finance	7	7.6%
	Healthcare	5	5.4%
	Other / Multiple	22	23.9%
Work Experience	Less than 1 year	58	63.0%
	1–3 years	18	19.6%
	3–5 years	6	6.5%
	5–10 years	5	5.4%
	More than 10 years	4	4.4%
Work Arrangement	Work from Office	43	46.7%
	Work from Home	28	30.4%
	Hybrid	16	17.4%
	Multiple / Other	5	5.4%
Per Day Work Hours	Less than 8 hours	46	50.0%
	8–9 hours	30	32.6%
	9–10 hours	12	13.0%
	More than 10 hours	4	4.4%
Overtime Frequency	Never	8	8.7%
	Rarely	8	8.7%
	Sometimes	40	43.5%
	Often	18	19.6%
	Always	18	19.6%

4.2 Descriptive Statistics: Likert Scale Items

Table 2 presents standard deviations and mean scores for all 17 Likert-scale items, rated on a five-count scale where 1 = Strongly Disagree and 5 = Strongly Agree.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics of Likert Scale Items (N = 92)

Survey Item	Mean	SD
Q8: My workload is manageable within my working hours	2.86	1.36
Q9: My job responsibilities interfere with my personal life	3.15	1.11
Q10: I maintain a good work-life balance	2.89	1.30
Q11: Manage time for family and personal activities	2.87	1.24
Q12: My organisation supports flexible working hours	2.78	1.24
Q13: Leave policies help maintain work-life balance	2.97	1.22
Q14: I feel stressed because of work responsibilities	3.10	1.03
Q15: Work-related stress affects my mental well-being	3.10	1.03
Q16: I feel emotionally exhausted after my workday	3.14	1.06
Q17: My organisation provides support for employee well-being	3.15	0.96
Q18: I am satisfied with my overall well-being at work	3.14	0.98
Q19: I feel productive during my working hours	3.41	0.88
Q20: Work-life balance improves my job performance	3.51	0.87
Q21: Stress reduces my focus and efficiency at work	3.20	1.03
Q22: I feel motivated to perform well in my job	3.51	0.85
Q23: My manager supports work-life balance	3.24	1.03
Q24: HR policies prioritise employee well-being	3.14	1.03

Examining individual items reveals noteworthy patterns. Workload manageability (Q8, mean = 2.86) and personal time adequacy (Q11, mean = 2.87) registered the lowest scores across the instrument, denoting widespread dissatisfaction with the boundary between professional demands and personal life. Stress-related items (Q14–Q16) clustered around 3.10–3.14, consistent with moderate to elevated psychological strain. Performance and motivation items (Q19–Q22) were the highest-rated in the survey, with Q20 and Q22 both recording means of 3.51 pointing to a sustained productive orientation even amid adverse WLB conditions.

4.3 Total Domain Scores

Four domain scores were produced for item scores within each thematic area. Table 3 presents these aggregated scores along with their interpretive classifications.

Table 3: Composite Domain Scores

Domain	Items Included	Composite Mean	Interpretation
Work-Life Balance	Q10, Q11	2.88	Below Moderate – Dissatisfied
Occupational Stress	Q14, Q15, Q16	3.11	Moderate-High – Stressed
Organisational Support	Q17, Q23, Q24	3.18	Moderate – Neutral-Positive
Job Performance & Motivation	Q19, Q20, Q21, Q22	3.41	Above Moderate – Positive

The composite data reveal a distinctive pattern: although WLB is rated below the scale midpoint (2.88) and occupational stress registers at a moderate-to-elevated level (3.11), employees sustain above-average performance and motivation (3.41). This divergence suggests that organisational commitment and intrinsic drive may serve as partial buffers against the productivity consequences of WLB deterioration.

4.4 Work Arrangement and Work-Life Balance

Cross-tabulation analysis was performed to see the relationship of work arrangement type and composite WLB scores. Table 4 reports mean WLB scores disaggregated by primary work arrangement category.

Table 4: WLB Score by Work Arrangement

Work Arrangement	n	Mean WLB Score
Work from Office	43	3.00
Work from Home	28	2.93
Hybrid	16	2.41

A counterintuitive pattern emerges: hybrid employees report the lowest WLB mean (2.41), falling below both office-based (3.00) and home-based (2.93) groups. This outcome corresponds to the flexibility paradox

identified in international scholarship (Kelliher & Anderson, 2010), suggesting that the dual-environment demands of hybrid work may introduce cognitive and logistical burdens that negate the anticipated advantages of scheduling flexibility.

4.5 Working Hours and Occupational Stress

The link between average quotidian hours of work and occupational stress levels was examined via cross-tabulation. Table 5 displays mean stress composite scores disaggregated by quotidian hours of work category.

Table 5: Stress Score by Daily Hours of Work

Daily Hours of Works	n	Mean Stress Score
Less than 8 hours	46	2.89
8–9 hours	30	3.33
9–10 hours	12	3.42
More than 10 hours	4	3.08

A broadly positive trend is discernible: employees working 9–10 hours daily record the highest mean stress score (3.42), followed by those in the 8–9 hour bracket (3.33). The modest decline observed among those exceeding 10 hours per day (3.08) should be treated cautiously, as this subgroup comprises only four respondents a sample size sparse for well-founded inference.

4.6 Qualitative Findings: Employee Suggestions

Content analysis of open-ended responses to Q25 identified five recurrent improvement themes: (1) equitable workload distribution and task assignment; (2) provision of flexible working hours and remote work entitlements; (3) more transparent and consistently enforced HR policy communication; (4) enhanced wellness infrastructure, including structured mental health support; and (5) improved manager-employee communication and cultivation of a respectful workplace culture. Representative responses conveyed the need for fair task allocation, paid leave entitlements, and accessible HR channels for personal concerns. These qualitative insights corroborate the quantitative findings and provide a grounded basis for specific organisational interventions.

5. Key Findings

The empirical analysis generates six substantive findings with implications for WLB scholarship and organisational practice in India.

Finding 1 - Work-Life Imbalance is Common

The overall work-life balance score was 2.88, they are experiencing a below-average level of balance between work and personal life and many respondents said that the work stress affects their mental health, and 76.1% reported feeling emotionally tired after work. The low workload manage score of 2.86 also shows that many employees feel their workload is too much for them to complete within normal working hours.

Finding 2 - Occupational Stress is ordinary but common

The stress score was 3.11, it shows employees are facing a moderate level of stress. 34.8% of respondents accept or strongly accept that their work responsibilities cause stress, and 32.6% said the work are affecting their mental health, and 40.2% reported emotional exhaustion. This means stress is not limited to a few employees; it is a common issue across the sample.

Finding 3 - The Hybrid Work Paradox

The study found something unexpected about hybrid work. Although hybrid work is often seen as better for work-life balance, hybrid workers has the lowest work-life balance score, at 2.41. It suggests, hybrid work automatically improve work-life balance. If companies use hybrid work without setting clear work boundaries, managing workload properly, and supporting employees, it may actually create more pressure for workers.

Finding 4 - Employees Continue to Perform Despite Challenges

Even though employees reported poor work-life balance and moderate stress, their performance and motivation scores were still above average, at 3.41. And 59.8% of respondents agreed that work-life balance improves job performance, and 53.3% said they feel strongly motivated at work. It shows many employees still trying to perform well despite stress and workload pressure.

This may be because of personal motivation, professional responsibility, and workplace or social expectations that push employees to maintain output even in difficult conditions.

Finding 5 -Organisational Support Exists, but Needs Improvement

The organisational support score was 3.18, it means employees have a neutral and slightly positive view of HR policies and management support. Only 37.0% supports employee well-being, and only 37.9% felt that HR policies properly prioritise employee welfare. It means that while some support exists, organisations still need to improve their systems, communication, and employee well-being initiatives.

Finding 6 – Flexible Work Policy Gap: The flexibility score (Q12, mean = 2.78) is the lowest of all individual Likert items. This is especially significant given that 82.7% of respondents report overtime at least occasionally and 39.2% do so frequently, revealing a systemic misalignment between formally designated working hours and actual time demands.

6. Discussion

The discovery of this work resonates with and extend several interrelated scholarly traditions addressing WLB, occupational stress, and organisational support.

The documentation of widespread WLB dissatisfaction corroborates evidence from earlier Indian scholarship (Saini & Budhwar, 2008; Nilufar et al., 2009) and is congruent with international evidence that competitive pressures, digital connectivity, and inadequate boundary management collectively undermine employee well-being. The below-midpoint WLB composite (2.88) is especially concerning given the predominantly early-career profile of the sample: professionals who develop maladaptive work practices at the outset of their careers risk long-term burnout trajectories that impair both individual health and organisational talent retention.

The hybrid work paradox documented here is among the study's most theoretically significant contributions. The flexibility hypothesis would predict that hybrid arrangements yield superior WLB relative to fully office-based models (Allen et al., 2013); the present data invert this expectation. The outcome is fixed with the flexible dilemma thesis advanced by (Kelliher and Anderson, 2010), who said that the optional nature of hybrid flexibility shows that a powerful duty to conclude the commitment, neutralizing or reversing any balance benefits. As per Hobfoll (1989), every person has a limited amount of mental and physical energy, and when it gets used more than it is recovered, stress and tiredness increases. Hybrid employees, who keep shifting between home and office, face this problem a lot.

The score for organisational support was 3.18, means most companies are not properly taking care of their employee's well-being. Managers were better by the employees (mean = 3.24), the HR policies received lower ratings (mean = 3.14). It shows that even if managers try their best to support their team, the official rules and policies made by the organisation are not strong enough to back them up. Difference between the what managers want to do and what the system actually wants is something that was also highlighted by Kossek et al., (2011) between supervisor behavioral support and organisational policy support as complementary but distinct constructs. The low organisational flexibility score (Q12, mean = 2.78) further suggests that flexible work policies still does not convert into meaningful daily employee experience.

Qualitative findings articulate a clear employee mandate for structural reform, with equitable workload allocation, flexible scheduling, transparent HR communication, and mental health infrastructure emerging as the most consistently cited priorities. These fondness range nearly among best-practice prescriptions in HRM literature (Kossek & Michel, 2011) and provide a practical roadmap for organisational leaders.

7. Conclusion

This study gives an evidence-based understanding of work-life balance, work stress, organisational support, and job performance among 92 Indian professionals from different sectors.

All, the findings of employees are hard to maintain a healthy balance between work and personal life. Their work-life balance scores are below average, stress levels are moderate to high, and overtime is common. Employees are still showing good motivation and performance, which may be because of their personal resilience and commitment to work.

One important finding is the “hybrid work paradox.” This means that flexible or hybrid work arrangements, which are usually expected to improve work-life balance, were actually linked with poorer work-life balance when compared with traditional office-based work.

MNC should not focus on hybrid work, it alone is enough to improve work-life balance. It needs to be supported by clear work boundaries, proper workload planning, and systems that allow employees to mentally drained from work after the office. HR departments should focus more on checking workload fairly. The low workload manage score of to 2.86 shows that heavy workload is one of the main issues affecting employees. This area can improve create a meaningful improvement in work-life balance.

Organisations should see the employee wellness support valuable investment, not as benefit. It provides the mental health services, building the people support groups, and training managers to better support employees in managing work-life balance.

It important in India as many professionals are young to handle the stress, workload pressure, and personal well-being. The convenience sampling methodology and the concentration of replier in education field and early-career bracket constrain the findings. Upcoming study should show the linear designs, probability sampling, and sector-specific comparative analyses. The incorporation of physiological stress indicators and objective performance measures would enhance the structural equation modelling could be deployed to test mediation and moderation pathways.

It underscores the imperative of reconceptualizing work-life balance not as an employee welfare concern but as a strategic organizational priority with direct consequences for workforce health, talent retention, and sustained productivity.

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